

# HEAR, O ISRAEL

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*The One God, His Name, and the Mystery of His Fullness*

*“Hear, Israel: Yahweh is our God. Yahweh is one.”*

Deuteronomy 6:4 (WEB)

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## A Note on the Scriptures

Every verse is quoted from the **World English Bible (WEB)**, a public-domain translation free to read, copy, and share. The WEB renders God's personal name as "**Yahweh**," which is essential for a book about the name of God. Where the Hebrew and Greek matter, we will look underneath the English, but you do not need the original languages to follow.

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## A Note to Every Reader

Everything depends on this question. Not "does a god exist?" — but "who is the true God, and what is He like?" Get this wrong and everything downstream goes wrong; get it right and your whole life has found its center.

This book is about the God who introduced Himself to Israel with a name and a claim: *Yahweh is one*. We will take that confession with total seriousness — and then watch how the same Scriptures that guard God's oneness also reveal a fullness within it that no flat, solitary picture can contain.

**To the Christian:** this is the foundation under everything you believe.

**To the atheist or seeker:** start nowhere but the texts; follow what they actually say.

**To the Jewish reader:** the Shema is your treasure before it is anyone's, and we hold it with reverence. We will not caricature your faith. We believe these Scriptures reveal more than is often seen; you may disagree, and we will still call you friend.

**To the Muslim reader:** you confess that God is one and that idolatry is the gravest error. So do we. The dispute is not *whether* God is one but *who* the one God is — and that is worth examining together.

We compare beliefs; we never demean people. And we begin where Israel begins, every morning and every evening, with one sentence.

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# Chapter One — The Most Important Sentence

## The confession at the center of the world

There is a single sentence that a faithful Jew has recited twice a day for three thousand years, that mothers have whispered to children and martyrs have died with on their lips. It is called the *Shema*, after its first Hebrew word, "Hear":

*"Hear, Israel: Yahweh is our God. Yahweh is one. You shall love Yahweh your God with all your heart, with all your soul, and with all your might." — Deuteronomy 6:4-5 (WEB)*

Everything in the Bible rests on this rock. There is one God. He has a name — Yahweh. He alone is to be loved with the whole of one's being. Every other commandment is a footnote to this one.

And when Jesus of Nazareth was asked which commandment was the greatest, He did not offer a clever alternative. He quoted the Shema: "The first is, 'Hear, Israel, the Lord our God, the Lord is one'" (Mark 12:29-30). Whatever else this book claims, hear it now: **nothing in it asks you to abandon the Shema.** This is not a book that smuggles in extra gods. It is a book about who the one God of the Shema actually is.

## What "one" guards against

The oneness of God is not an abstract math fact. It is a fence around the human heart. Because God is one, He alone is worthy of worship; everything else — money, power, sex, self, the state, even religion itself — is a counterfeit when it takes His place. The first and second commandments draw the line: "You shall have no other gods before me. You shall not make for yourself an idol" (Exodus 20:3-4). Idolatry — giving to a created thing the trust and worship owed to the Creator — is the great sin precisely *because* God is one.

This is why the question "who is God?" is never merely intellectual. To know the true God is to know what your life is *for*. To mistake Him is to spend your life worshipping something that cannot save.

## A God who can be known

The most hopeful thing about the Shema is the word "our." "Yahweh is *our* God." The infinite Creator is not a distant abstraction to be guessed at; He has made Himself known, entered into covenant, and given His name. The rest of this book traces that self-revelation — and it starts with the most famous self-introduction in history, at a burning bush.

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# Chapter Two — The Name

## "What is his name?"

Moses stands before a bush that burns but is not consumed, and the voice from the fire commissions him to free Israel. Moses asks the question everyone eventually asks: when they want to know who sent me, "What is his name?" And God answers with a sentence that has occupied theologians ever since:

*"God said to Moses, 'I AM WHO I AM,' and he said, 'You shall tell the children of Israel this: 'I AM has sent me to you.'"" — Exodus 3:14 (WEB)*

"I AM WHO I AM." In Hebrew, *ehyeh asher ehyeh* — a phrase built from the verb "to be." From it comes the sacred name, **YHWH** (Yahweh), which means something like "He Is," "the One who is," "the Self-Existent One." God's name is, astonishingly, a statement of pure being. Everything else that exists was made and could just as easily not exist. God simply *is* — uncreated, dependent on nothing, the source of all that is.

## A name that means He needs nothing

Pause on what this implies. A God whose name is "I AM" did not begin. He has no maker, no rival, no expiration. He does not need the universe; the universe needs Him every instant to continue existing. As Paul told the philosophers of Athens, this God is not "served by men's hands, as though he needed anything, seeing he himself gives to all life and breath, and all things" (Acts 17:25). The burning bush is the perfect emblem: a fire that needs no fuel, blazing on its own life.

## The name above every name

Israel held this name in such awe that they would not pronounce it, saying "the LORD" instead. It is the most sacred word in the Hebrew Scriptures. So keep this in mind for later, because it will matter enormously: when the New Testament says God gave Jesus "the name which is above every name" (Philippians 2:9), and applies to Jesus the words Yahweh spoke — that is not a small thing. It is a claim staked on this very name from the bush. But we are getting ahead of ourselves. First we must ask whether this transcendent "I AM" can have anything to do with us at all.

# Chapter Three — Is God a Man?

## The God who is not a creature

The Bible is emphatic that God is utterly unlike us. He is not a bigger, stronger version of a human being. "God is not a man, that he should lie, nor a son of man, that he should repent" (Numbers 23:19). He is spirit (John 4:24), eternal (Psalm 90:2), unchanging, present everywhere, knowing everything. He cannot be carved, contained, or controlled. This is His *transcendence* — He is above and beyond His creation.

This is the truth that idolatry forgets. To shrink God down to a statue, a force, or a projection of ourselves is to worship something less than God. The prophets pour scorn on the folly of a man who carves wood, burns half for warmth, and bows to the other half (Isaiah 44:14-17). The true God will not fit in a box.

## The God who comes near

And yet — here is the wonder that runs all through the Old Testament — this transcendent God is also astonishingly *near*. He walks in a garden. He shuts the door of the ark. He eats a meal with Abraham. He wrestles with Jacob, who then says, "I have seen God face to face, and my life is preserved" (Genesis 32:30). He comes down on Sinai in fire. He fills a tent with His glory and travels with a band of former slaves through a desert.

Most striking of all is a recurring figure the Old Testament calls **the Angel of Yahweh** — a messenger who is somehow both *distinct from* Yahweh and *identified as* Yahweh. He appears to Hagar, and she calls Him "a God who sees" (Genesis 16:13). He speaks from the burning bush as God. He receives worship that ordinary angels refuse. One of your own Scroll threads sat right here, at this strange figure who blesses, saves, and bears the very name of God while standing before us as a distinct person. The Old Testament is already hinting that God's nearness has a *face*.

## A nearness the heart longs for

When Jacob wakes from his dream of the ladder he cries, "Surely Yahweh is in this place, and I didn't know it" (Genesis 28:16). That is the ache of the whole Old Testament — the sense that the transcendent God is somehow present, and the longing to truly see Him. The Scriptures keep raising a hope they cannot yet satisfy: that the God who is "I AM" might one day be seen and known, face to face, without anyone being destroyed. That hope is not idle. It is being prepared. But first we must notice something hidden inside the oneness itself.



# Chapter Four — The Fullness Within the One

## A plural hint on the first page

Return to the very beginning. On the sixth day, God says something that has puzzled readers for millennia:

*"God said, 'Let us make man in our image, after our likeness.'" — Genesis 1:26*  
(WEB)

*Us. Our.* The one God speaks of Himself in the plural. Some explain this as God addressing angels — but angels are not co-creators, and humanity is made in *God's* image, not the angels'. Others call it a royal "we." But the hint does not stand alone. Already in Genesis 1:2 "the Spirit of God was hovering over the surface of the waters" — God, and the Spirit of God, both present at creation. And throughout the Old Testament, the "Word" of Yahweh and the "Wisdom" of God act as if they are more than poetic figures (Proverbs 8; Psalm 33:6).

We must be careful here, and honest. None of this *by itself* proves the doctrine of the Trinity, and we will not pretend it does. What it shows is that the oneness of the God of Israel was never the flat, solitary oneness of a single isolated person. There is a fullness, a complexity, a "within-ness" to God that the Hebrew Scriptures themselves keep gesturing toward.

## "Two powers in heaven"

This is not a Christian imposition on the text. Ancient Jewish interpreters wrestled with the same data. The Scriptures show Yahweh on earth talking with Yahweh in heaven (Genesis 19:24); they show a figure called the Word, the Angel, the Wisdom of God acting *as* God yet *distinct* from God. So strong were these threads that some rabbis spoke of "two powers in heaven" — and the later authorities worked hard to rule the idea out, precisely because some Jews were drawing from their own Scriptures the very conclusion the New Testament would draw. The point is simple and important: the question of plurality-within-the-one arises *from the Hebrew Bible itself*, not from outside it.

## A throne, and Someone seated on it

Then the prophet Daniel sees the curtain pulled back. In heaven, "the Ancient of Days" takes His throne — and then "one like a son of man came with the clouds of the sky," approached



the Ancient of Days, and was given "dominion, and glory, and a kingdom, that all the peoples, nations, and languages should serve him" (Daniel 7:13-14). Here are two distinct figures in the one heavenly throne-room, and to the human-yet-heavenly one is given the worship and everlasting kingdom that, by the Shema, belong to God alone. The fullness within the One is coming into focus. The Old Testament has been preparing us, slowly, to meet Him.

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# Chapter Five — Father, Son, and Holy Spirit

## The fullness with a face

What the Old Testament hinted, the New Testament unveils — not by adding gods, but by revealing that the one God has eternally existed as Father, Son, and Holy Spirit. The Word who was with God and was God "became flesh and lived among us" (John 1:1, 14). The ache of Jacob — "surely God is in this place" — is answered: in Jesus, the "I AM" of the burning bush has a face. "He who has seen me has seen the Father" (John 14:9).

Watch how the persons appear together, distinct yet one. At Jesus' baptism the Son stands in the water, the Spirit descends like a dove, and the Father's voice speaks from heaven: "This is my beloved Son" (Matthew 3:16-17) — three, at once, in one scene. Jesus sends His followers to baptize "in *the name*" — singular — "of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit" (Matthew 28:19): one name, three persons. Paul blesses the church with "the grace of the Lord Jesus Christ, God's love, and the fellowship of the Holy Spirit" (2 Corinthians 13:14).

## Not three gods, not one mask

The church's confession — what later came to be called the Trinity — holds two truths together without dropping either. *God is one* (the Shema stands). And *the one God is Father, Son, and Holy Spirit*, three distinct persons sharing one undivided being.

This is not three gods. That would be tritheism, and it would break the Shema. Nor is it one person wearing three masks — Father today, Son tomorrow — which the early church rejected as modalism, because the Son prays to the Father (John 17), the Father speaks to the Son, and they love one another "before the foundation of the world" (John 17:24). A mask cannot love itself across eternity. The relationship is real and eternal.

## Why the word "Trinity" is not in the Bible — and the reality is

Some object that the word "Trinity" never appears in Scripture. True — and neither does "monotheism," yet the Bible is thoroughly monotheistic. "Trinity" is the church's faithful shorthand for what the Bible everywhere teaches: one God (Deuteronomy 6:4), the Father is God, the Son is God (John 1:1; John 20:28), the Spirit is God (Acts 5:3-4), and they are distinct. The word summarizes the data; it does not invent it. The God who said "let us" in the garden, who appeared as the Angel who is Yahweh, who showed Daniel two thrones, has

stepped fully into the light. He is one — and He is fullness of life and love within Himself.

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# Chapter Six — Besides Me There Is No Savior

## The God who shares His glory with no one

If God is one, then He alone can save, and He will not hand His glory to a rival. Yahweh says it through Isaiah with total finality:

*"I, even I, am Yahweh; and besides me there is no savior." — Isaiah 43:11 (WEB)*

*"Look to me, and be saved, all the ends of the earth; for I am God, and there is no other." — Isaiah 45:22 (WEB)*

This is the most exclusive claim imaginable. Salvation comes from Yahweh alone. Worship belongs to Yahweh alone. "To me every knee will bow, every tongue will swear" (Isaiah 45:23). To give that worship to any creature would be the very idolatry the Shema forbids.

## Why this is the hinge of everything

Hold those verses next to what the New Testament says about Jesus, and you face a decision with no middle ground. The earliest Christians — Jews who would have died before bowing to an idol — took Isaiah's no-knee-bows-but-to-God text and applied it directly to Jesus: "at the name of Jesus every knee should bow... and every tongue should confess that Jesus is Lord, to the glory of God the Father" (Philippians 2:10-11). They took the saving God "besides whom there is no savior" and confessed, "There is salvation in no one else" — in Jesus (Acts 4:12).

Either this is blasphemy — giving God's glory to a creature — or it is the unveiling of who the one God always was. There is no third option where Jesus is merely a great prophet who happens to receive the worship reserved for Yahweh. The Shema forces the question to a point: *is the Lord Jesus the one Lord God, or not?* This ministry's companion book, *I Am He*, follows that single thread in detail. Here it is enough to see that the exclusive, saving, glory-jealous God of Isaiah is the God the New Testament says we meet in Christ.

## One God for all the nations

And notice the reach of it — "all the ends of the earth." The one God is not a tribal deity for one people. He is the Creator of every nation, and His salvation is offered to all. As Paul told the Athenians, "He made from one blood every nation of men to dwell on all the surface of the

earth... that they should seek the Lord, if perhaps they might reach out for him and find him, though he is not far from each one of us" (Acts 17:26-27). The Shema's "our God" was always meant to open outward until the whole earth is filled with the knowledge of His glory.

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# Chapter Seven — Knowing God

## From information to worship

You can know a great deal *about* God and never know *Him* — just as you can memorize a person's biography and never meet them. The point of all the doctrine in this book is not to win arguments. It is to bring you to the place where information becomes worship, where "I AM" becomes "*my* God."

The Bible promises this is possible — indeed it is the entire goal. Jeremiah foretold a day when God's people "shall all know me, from the least of them to the greatest" (Jeremiah 31:34). Jesus said eternal life *is* this knowing: "This is eternal life, that they should know you, the only true God, and him whom you sent, Jesus Christ" (John 17:3). To know God is not the reward at the end of the Christian life; it is the Christian life.

## How the unknowable God can be known

So how does a finite, sinful person come to know the infinite, holy God? Not by climbing up to Him through cleverness or merit — we cannot. The wonder of the gospel is that He came down. The "I AM" who could not be looked upon at Sinai became approachable in Jesus, "the image of the invisible God" (Colossians 1:15). "No one has seen God at any time. The one and only Son... has declared him" (John 1:18). If you want to know what God is like — His heart, His holiness, His mercy toward sinners — look at Jesus, and you are looking at God making Himself known.

And the knowing is not merely intellectual; it is by the Spirit. The same God who is Father and Son is the Spirit who "searches all things, yes, the deep things of God" (1 Corinthians 2:10) and who opens the eyes of the heart. To know God truly, you must be brought to Him by God Himself.

## The first step into the knowing

Which means the question this whole book has been circling lands, finally, on you. You have heard who God is: the one Yahweh, the "I AM," transcendent yet near, full of life and love within Himself, Father, Son, and Holy Spirit, the only Savior, who made every nation and is "not far from each one of us." The Shema's command was never merely "believe that God is one." It was "*love* Yahweh your God with all your heart." Knowledge is meant to become love.

You can begin to know Him today. Turn from whatever has held the place that belongs to God alone — that is repentance. Trust the Son in whom the invisible God has drawn near — that is faith. Call on Him, for "everyone who will call on the name of the Lord will be saved" (Romans 10:13). You might pray, simply: *God, I want to know you — the true God, not an idol of my own making. I have given your place to other things, and I turn from them. I trust Jesus, in whom you came near. Make yourself known to me, and be my God.*

The God whose name is "I AM" has been saying, in effect, from the burning bush to the empty tomb: *I am here. I am near. Hear, and live.*

*"You will seek me, and find me, when you search for me with all your heart." —  
Jeremiah 29:13 (WEB)*

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# Honest Questions

No doctrine raises more honest questions than the doctrine of God. Here are the ones most often asked — from believers and skeptics alike — answered briefly and without evasion.

## "Isn't the Trinity a contradiction — three is not one?"

Only if we say God is three *and* one in the *same way* — three persons and one person, or three gods and one god. That would be a contradiction, and the church has never taught it. We say God is one in one respect (one Being, one "What") and three in another (three persons, three "Whos"). One *what*, three *whos*. There is no more contradiction in that than in saying a single human being has one nature and a single will, or that one triangle has three sides — the categories are different. Mystery is not the same as contradiction. The doctrine is *above* our full comprehension, as the infinite God must be; it is not *against* reason.

## "Was the Trinity invented at the Council of Nicaea (325)?"

No. Nicaea *defended* what the church had believed and worshipped from the start, against a new teaching (Arianism) that the Son was a created being. The raw materials were all there centuries earlier: the Word who "was God" (John 1:1, c. AD 90), the worship of Jesus in the earliest letters (Philippians 2:9-11, a hymn Paul *quotes*, meaning it was older still), baptism in the threefold name (Matthew 28:19), and the apostolic blessing of Father, Son, and Spirit (2 Corinthians 13:14). Councils put fences around old beliefs; they do not manufacture them. The word "Trinity" is later shorthand; the reality is apostolic.

## "If Jesus is God, why did He pray, and why did He say 'the Father is greater than I' (John 14:28)?"

Because the Son became truly human. Christians do not believe Jesus stopped being God; we believe the eternal Son took on a full human nature — "the Word became flesh" (John 1:14). As man, He prayed, grew tired, wept, and depended on the Father. "The Father is greater than I" speaks of His role and His state in the incarnation (the sent One, in the lowliness of human flesh), not of a lesser nature — for in the very same Gospel He says, "I and the Father are one" (John 10:30), and "he who has seen me has seen the Father" (John 14:9). A son can be fully equal to his father in nature while submitting to him in role. So it is with the eternal Son.



## "Doesn't Jesus' not knowing the day or hour (Mark 13:32) prove He isn't God?"

It proves He is truly *human*. In taking our nature, the Son lived within real human limits — He "increased in wisdom" as a child (Luke 2:52), grew hungry, and, in His humanity, did not draw on all divine knowledge at every moment. This is the wonder of the incarnation, not its undoing: the infinite One stooped to live a genuinely human life. The same Jesus also knew people's hidden thoughts (Mark 2:8), knew the future in detail, and accepted worship. Scripture holds His full deity and full humanity together; cherry-picking the human moments no more disproves His deity than the divine moments disprove His humanity.

## "What about Psalm 82, where God calls others 'gods'?"

Psalm 82 pictures God standing in judgment over the "gods" — most likely Israel's *judges* or rulers (or, on another reading, spiritual powers) who were entrusted with authority and abused it: "I said, 'You are gods'... Nevertheless you shall die like men" (Psalm 82:6-7). The point is the *opposite* of polytheism: these so-called "gods" are mortal and will be judged by the one true God. When Jesus cites this psalm (John 10:34-36), He is making a lesser-to-greater argument — if Scripture could call mere mortal judges "gods" in that delegated sense, the charge of blasphemy against the One the Father truly sanctified and sent is unfounded. Psalm 82 does not dilute monotheism; it dramatizes it.

## "Isn't it arrogant to say there is only one true God?"

Every worldview makes a truth claim, including the claim that "all paths are equally valid" (which is itself an exclusive claim that excludes those who disagree). The question is not whether someone is making a claim, but whether the claim is *true*. If God has actually revealed Himself — with a name, in history, supremely in a Person who rose from the dead — then to receive that revelation is not arrogance but humility before the evidence. And the God who says "besides me there is no savior" also says, in the same breath, "Look to me, and be saved, all the ends of the earth" (Isaiah 45:22). The exclusivity and the open invitation are the same sentence.

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## Appendix — Key Texts on the One God

A reference table for the doctrine of God traced in this book.

| Truth                   | Key text (WEB)                                                                                                       |
|-------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| God is one              | "Hear, Israel: Yahweh is our God. Yahweh is one."<br>(Deuteronomy 6:4)                                               |
| God's name is "I AM"    | "I AM WHO I AM... I AM has sent me to you."<br>(Exodus 3:14)                                                         |
| God is not a creature   | "God is not a man, that he should lie." (Numbers<br>23:19)                                                           |
| Plurality on page one   | "Let us make man in our image." (Genesis 1:26)                                                                       |
| The Spirit at creation  | "The Spirit of God was hovering over the surface of<br>the waters." (Genesis 1:2)                                    |
| Two figures, one throne | "One like a son of man came... to the Ancient of<br>Days." (Daniel 7:13-14)                                          |
| The Word was God        | "The Word was with God, and the Word was God."<br>(John 1:1)                                                         |
| The threefold name      | "baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the<br>Son and of the Holy Spirit." (Matthew 28:19)                 |
| The triune blessing     | "The grace of the Lord Jesus Christ, God's love, and<br>the fellowship of the Holy Spirit." (2 Corinthians<br>13:14) |
| The only Savior         | "I, even I, am Yahweh; and besides me there is no<br>savior." (Isaiah 43:11)                                         |
| One God for all nations | "Look to me, and be saved, all the ends of the earth."<br>(Isaiah 45:22)                                             |
| Knowing God is life     | "This is eternal life, that they should know you, the<br>only true God." (John 17:3)                                 |

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## Conclusion — Hear, and Live

The most important sentence in the world is still true: *Yahweh is our God. Yahweh is one.* This book has not undermined that confession; it has tried to open it — to show that the oneness of God is not a lonely, flat oneness but a fullness of life and love, eternally Father, Son, and Holy

Spirit; that this one God has a name, "I AM," and a face, Jesus Christ; that He alone saves, and He is near.

To know this God is what you were made for. Everything else — every lesser god you might serve — will fail you. He will not. Hear, O Israel; hear, all the ends of the earth — and live.

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## About this book

*Hear, O Israel* is published freely by **Hope of Glory Ministry**, that the earth may be filled with the knowledge of the glory of the Lord. It may be read, shared, and given away without charge. All Scripture is from the World English Bible (public domain). We hold the historic Nicene faith and the plain reading of Scripture; we compare beliefs and never demean persons.

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*"For the earth will be filled with the knowledge of the glory of Yahweh, as the waters cover the sea." — Habakkuk 2:14 (WEB)*